and encourage the attacks against the Rohingyas, not out of blind bloodlust, but because they deem it ‘necessary’. But the majority of Burmese do not even condone the violence. Yet they also do not especially mind the violence because the victims are Muslims. And they also agree that everything would be better if the Rohingyas had already been moved to Bangladesh. So really it is the Rohingyas’ fault that they are being attacked, because they are still hanging around in the country of their birth. Those are the social attitudes which will enable a genocide. And from those attitudes, it takes little to push it past the point of no return.

After the 2012–13 assaults on the Rohingya community, the great majority found themselves in internal refugee camps. Here they were denied the means to work or to travel, access to health care or education. This clustering of an already vulnerable community into large camps has been a source of concern as it would make it easier for any future ethnic violence to become an act of genocide. By mid-2016, it was becoming increasingly clear that the persecution of the Rohingyas was being renewed, and the threat of a full-fledged genocidal frenzy looked as imminent as ever.

Still, the renewed violence followed a pattern already established since 2012. The Burmese army and its local Rakhine allies started to burn the homes of those Rohingyas living outside the refugee camps. This period saw killings and a renewed refugee exodus but came to an end in October 2016. The violence led to a more robust international response, and the involvement of Kofi Annan. The NLD has responded in the same way that the old military regime had to brief periods of international pressure. It has tried to prevent any external oversight by the UN or by journalists. It has also steadily banned all aid agencies from Rakhine, insisting that all aid be channelled through the Myanmar regime—and thus denied to the Rohingyas.

But what looked like a familiar cycle masked some fundamental changes in the underlying dynamic between the Rohingyas and their oppressors. This time around, the NLD were in government. And that made no difference. Hope is one of the most powerful forces in politics. So long as the NLD had been in opposition and had a viable way to power, the Rohingyas maintained hope. That hope held the community together and kept them tied to Myanmar and to the project of reconciliation with the Myanmar federal state. But now, those hopes have proved entirely forlorn.